Sample document HOM-2024-SAMPLE-001

Home Insurance Policy 2024

Omen Shield Home Policy — Buildings, Contents and Personal Possessions

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1. Important Notice and About This Policy

This is a SAMPLE document created for demonstration and training purposes only. Omen United Insurance is a fictional insurer and every policy number, figure, limit and address in this wording is invented. This document must not be used as real insurance advice, and no real coverage is provided by it. It is included in the Omen demo knowledge base so that assistants can answer questions about how a typical home insurance policy is structured.

This policy wording sets out the terms under which Omen United Insurance (referred to in this document as “we”, “us” or “Omen”) will pay for loss of or damage to your home and its contents. The wording is divided into sections: Section A covers the buildings, Section B covers home contents, and Section C covers personal possessions taken outside the home. Optional extensions, such as accidental damage and home emergency, are described in the Optional Extras section of this wording.

Your policy schedule shows the sections you have purchased, the sums insured, the excess amounts that apply to each section, and any endorsements specific to your address. Where the schedule and this wording differ, the schedule takes priority. Please read both documents together and keep them in a safe place, because the claims procedure in Section 18 refers to information that appears only on the schedule.

2. Summary of Cover

The table below summarises the standard limits under the Omen Shield Home Policy. Each limit is the maximum we will pay for any one claim under that heading, unless your schedule states a higher or lower figure. The excess shown in the final column is the amount you must pay towards each claim; a more detailed excess table appears in Section 16.

Cover section	Standard limit (sample)	Excess
Buildings (Section A)	£400,000 rebuild cost	£250 standard
Home contents (Section B)	£50,000 total sum insured	£250 standard
Single article limit (contents)	£2,500 per item	£250
Personal possessions (Section C)	£7,500 total	£250
Bicycles (unspecified)	£500 aggregate	£250
Garden equipment	£2,500 aggregate	£250
Home office equipment	£5,000 aggregate	£250
Flood (buildings and contents)	Section limit	£500
Subsidence and ground movement	£Section limit	£1,000
Escape of water	Section limit	£350

Cover is provided on a new-for-old (replacement as new) basis for contents, which means we replace a damaged or destroyed item with a new equivalent item of the same kind and quality, without deduction for wear and tear. Clothing and linen are covered on a new-for-old basis only if they are less than five years old at the date of loss. Buildings cover operates on a reinstatement basis, meaning the sum insured must reflect the full cost of rebuilding the property, including professional fees and debris removal.

3. Section A — Buildings Cover

Section A covers the domestic buildings at the address shown on your policy schedule, including the structure of the house or flat, garages, outbuildings, greenhouses, walls, gates, fences, hedges, terraces, patios, drives, swimming pools and tennis courts, all within the boundaries of the insured address. Fixtures and fittings that would normally be left behind if you moved, such as fitted kitchens, fitted wardrobes, bathroom suites and central heating installations, are treated as part of the buildings.

The buildings sum insured must equal the full rebuilding cost of the property, not its market value. Rebuilding cost includes the cost of demolition, site clearance, architects' and surveyors' fees, and compliance with current building regulations. If the sum insured is less than the full rebuilding cost, we will apply the average provision described in Section 20, which reduces the amount we pay in proportion to the degree of under-insurance.

Buildings cover responds to insured events including fire, smoke, lightning, explosion, storm, flood, escape of water from fixed installations, theft or attempted theft resulting in damage to the building, subsidence, landslip or heave of the site, and impact by vehicles, falling trees or aircraft. Each of these events is subject to the excesses set out in Section 16 and to the general exclusions in Section 15.

Loft conversions, extensions and structural alterations are covered only if you have notified us of the work before it begins and the rebuilding cost has been adjusted accordingly. Temporary alternative accommodation, up to 20 per cent of the buildings sum insured, is payable under Section A if the home becomes uninhabitable after an insured event, for as long as reinstatement reasonably takes, to a maximum of 24 months.

4. Section B — Home Contents Cover

Section B covers household goods, furnishings, furniture, domestic appliances, audio-visual and computer equipment, clothing, linen, sports equipment, garden furniture and equipment kept at the insured address, and food and drink in freezers or refrigerators. Contents are covered while they are within the home, in outbuildings and garages at the same address, and in the open areas of the insured grounds.

The contents sum insured must represent the full replacement cost of all contents as new. Single articles, pairs, sets or collections worth more than the single article limit of £2,500 must be specified individually on the schedule; unspecified items are limited to £2,500 each in any one claim. Valuables — defined as jewellery, watches, furs, items of gold, silver or other precious metals, pictures and other works of art, stamps and coin collections — have an overall limit of one third of the contents sum insured within any one claim, unless otherwise agreed.

Contents in the open air within the insured boundary are covered against theft only if there is evidence of violent and forcible entry to a locked building or an attended area. Money and gift cards are covered up to £500 in total; credit cards are covered only for their fraudulent use occurring within 48 hours before you first notify the issuing institution. Pedal cycles are covered at the insured address under Section B, and away from the address only if specified under Section C.

5. Section C — Personal Possessions Away From Home

Section C, which must be purchased as an addition to Section B, covers personal possessions, clothing, sports equipment, musical instruments and other portable items that belong to you or to family members permanently residing with you, anywhere in the United Kingdom, and for up to 60 days in any one period of insurance elsewhere in the world. Cover under this section operates on an all-risks basis, which means that possessions are insured against any accidental loss or damage, subject only to the exclusions stated in this wording.

The maximum any one article limit under Section C is £2,500 unless the article is specified. Bicycles must be individually specified to be covered away from the home, and specified bicycles are covered against theft only when secured by an approved lock to an immovable object. Photographic equipment, laptops and portable electronic equipment are subject to a combined limit of £5,000 in any one claim unless specified on the schedule.

Personal money is covered under Section C up to £500. Business samples and trade equipment owned by you are covered up to £2,500 in total. Weddings, civil partnership celebrations and religious festivals receive an automatic 10 per cent increase in the contents sum insured for a period of seven days immediately before and after the event, reflecting the additional gifts, clothing and equipment typically present at the home during such occasions.

6. Flood and Water Damage

Flood cover is included as standard under both Section A and Section B of the Omen Shield Home Policy. Flood means covering by water from rivers, canals, lakes, the sea or other natural watercourses, and also surface water caused by rainfall or melting snow that has not entered through the drainage system. A flood claim carries a specific excess of £500, which replaces the standard £250 excess, as shown in the excess table in Section 16.

It is important to distinguish flood from escape of water. Escape of water means water leaking from fixed domestic installations such as burst pipes, overflowing baths, failed washing machine hoses or leaking central heating systems. Escape of water claims carry an excess of £350. Both flood and escape of water cover the resulting damage to buildings and contents, but neither covers the cost of repairing the source of the leak itself — for example, replacing the section of pipe that burst — unless the pipe was damaged by an insured event such as a fire.

Gradual deterioration is excluded throughout the policy. Damage that occurs slowly over weeks or months, persistent drips that you were aware of and did not repair, wet rot, dry rot, and condensation are not insured, because home insurance responds to sudden and unforeseen events rather than maintenance issues. If a slow leak is discovered, we will pay for the damage caused by the sudden failure, but not for damage that accumulated over time where a reasonable homeowner would have taken action.

After a flood, you must take all reasonable steps to remove water and dry the property. Our emergency network will arrange dehumidification and, where buildings cover applies, we will pay for the cost of pumping out water, drying out, and sanitising the property as part of the claim. Alternative accommodation is available under Section A while the home is uninhabitable. Further guidance appears in the claims procedure in Section 18.

7. Fire, Smoke and Explosion

Fire and smoke damage is covered under Sections A and B, including scorching where a fire has actually occurred, and damage caused by soot and smoke from a fire within the home or from a neighbouring property. Damage caused by heat without ignition — for example, a warped worktop caused by a hot pan — is not fire damage, but may be covered under the accidental damage extension described in Section 11 if purchased.

Explosion, whether within or outside the home, is insured, including the effects of sonic bangs from aircraft travelling at or beyond the speed of sound. Lightning strike is insured as a standard peril; typically it damages electrical equipment and induces power surges, which are covered under buildings and contents where the lightning caused the surge. Power surges arising from failures in the public electricity supply that are not caused by lightning are covered only under the optional home electrical extension.

Following a fire, the sum insured should allow for the full cost of reinstatement, including smoke odour removal, cleaning of undamaged items, and reinstatement matching — where, for example, a destroyed tiled floor cannot be matched, we will pay to retile the entire connected area so the finish is uniform. Fire brigade charges up to £1,500 are payable under Section A where a fire or rescue service makes a statutory charge.

8. Storm Damage

Storm cover applies to damage caused by abnormally severe weather, including high winds, hailstorms, and the weight of snow. There is no separate storm excess; the standard £250 excess applies. Damage to fences, gates and hedges caused by storm is excluded, because these items are the items most frequently damaged by wind and their exclusion keeps premiums affordable. Damage to garden trees is covered only for the cost of removing the fallen tree from the insured property; the value of the tree itself is not insured.

Storm claims are assessed with reference to meteorological data. Where damage is caused by weather that is normal for the season and the region — for instance, a lost roof tile during ordinary gales on an ageing roof — the claim may be declined as wear and tear rather than storm damage. Roof coverings must be maintained in a sound condition, wind-lifted tiles on a roof that was already in poor repair are excluded under the wear-and-tear provisions in Section 15.

9. Theft and Burglary

Theft cover under Sections A and B responds to loss or damage caused by theft, attempted theft, or vandalism that follows a break-in. There must be evidence of violent and forcible entry to or exit from the building for a theft claim to succeed. Marks of forcible entry may be to any part of the building, including doors, windows, roof lights or walls. Where property is stolen from an outbuilding, garage or shed, forcible entry to that structure must also be shown.

Theft from the home by family members, invited guests, tenants or domestic employees is excluded, as is theft of items left in the open within the boundary unless violent and forcible entry to a secured area can be demonstrated. Keys obtained by deception — the so-called fake caller scenario — are covered only where the burglar entered the home by using violence against the fabric of the building, not where they entered using a legitimately obtained key without damage.

A theft excess of £250 applies to each theft claim. You must report the theft to the police as soon as reasonably possible and obtain an incident reference number; claims are usually declined where no crime reference exists. Following a theft involving keys, locks and any electronically operated access devices must be replaced, and we will pay for replacement locks and keys up to £750 in total under Sections A and B combined.

10. Subsidence and Ground Movement

Subsidence, landslip and heave of the site beneath the home are covered under Section A, subject to a specific excess of £1,000 for each subsidence claim. Subsidence means the downward movement of the ground supporting the property, often associated with clay soils that shrink in dry weather, or with water leaking from drains that washes away finer soil particles. Heave is the opposite — upward movement — and landslip is the sideways movement of the ground down a slope.

The subsidence excess applies per building, per period of insurance, not per claim: where a series of claims arises from the same subsidence event during one period of insurance, only one £1,000 excess is deducted in total. Root damage caused by trees and shrubs is covered, including the cost of removing the responsible tree and underpinning the affected walls, but the value of the tree itself is not covered, and the cost of remedial action taken purely to prevent future subsidence — such as pruning a healthy tree — is not insured.

Coastal erosion, and damage arising from mining, quarrying or demolition activities, is excluded under this policy unless specially endorsed. Properties built on made-up ground or over historical mine workings require disclosure at inception; where such properties are accepted, a specific endorsement stating the applicable terms will appear on your schedule.

11. Accidental Damage Extension (Optional)

The accidental damage extension is an optional addition to Sections A and B that broadens cover to include sudden and unforeseen damage caused by a one-off accident. Typical accidental damage claims include a television knocked from its stand, a football smashing a greenhouse pane, a nail driven through a water pipe while hanging a picture, spillage on a carpet or sofa, and a worktop scorched by a hot pan.

The extension does not cover damage happening gradually, damage caused deliberately, damage to property being worked on by tradespeople where the damage arises from the work itself, damage to clothing by pets, or the failure of any component as a result of a manufacturing defect. Computer data loss is covered only as physical damage to the medium that stores the data; the cost of recreating data itself is not covered.

Accidental damage claims attract the standard £250 excess. Where a single accident damages both buildings and contents — for example, a bath overflowing causes water damage to the floor and to belongings below — a single excess applies to the combined claim rather than one excess per section.

12. Garden Equipment, Bicycles and Outbuildings

Garden furniture, lawnmowers, strimmers, barbecues, power tools kept in a shed, ornamental planters, and garden ornaments are covered under Section B up to a combined garden equipment limit of £2,500 in any one claim, provided they are within the boundaries of the insured address. Items stored in the open — such as garden furniture left on a terrace — are covered against theft only when locked away in a building or secured structure overnight.

Bicycles at the insured address are covered under the garden equipment and general contents provisions up to an unspecified aggregate limit of £500 per claim. Any bicycle worth more than £500 must be specified individually on the schedule; a specified bicycle attracts its own sum insured and is covered away from the home under Section C against theft only when secured with an approved lock. Competitive cycling events, racing and time trials are excluded for both specified and unspecified bicycles.

Outbuildings — sheds, garages, greenhouses and summer houses — are covered as part of Section A, but tools and equipment owned for business use and stored in outbuildings are limited to £2,500 in total unless a business extension has been purchased. Trampolines, above-ground swimming pools and climbing frames are covered as garden structures under Section A against insured events, but not against collapse caused by gradual weakening of joints or supports.

13. Home Office and Business Use

A growing number of households run office space at home, and the Omen Shield policy provides a home office equipment limit of £5,000 in total under Section B for computers, printers, monitors, office furniture and related equipment used for clerical, administrative or study purposes. Where business stock or trade equipment is kept at the address, the standard limit is £2,500 unless the business contents extension has been purchased.

Business use beyond clerical work — including client visits, giving tuition at home, mail order trading and storage of goods for sale — requires notification, and cover will be extended by endorsement to reflect the increased exposure. The home emergency and alternative accommodation provisions are unaffected by home office use, but any liability arising from the business itself is covered only under a separate business policy.

14. Liability to the Public

Under both Sections A and B we will pay amounts you become legally liable to pay as compensation for accidental bodily injury to any person, or accidental loss of or damage to their property, occurring in connection with the insured address or your domestic activities. The limit is £2,000,000 for any one occurrence, including legal costs incurred with our written agreement. Cover extends to liability arising as a private householder, tenant or occupier, and to the domestic activities of family members living with you.

Cover also extends to your liability as owner or occupier for incidents away from the home that arise from your domestic life — for example, injury to a third party caused by your child at a park. Liability arising from the ownership or use of motor vehicles, aircraft, watercraft and dogs of restricted breeds is excluded, because separate insurance arrangements are legally required for those exposures.

15. General Exclusions

The following exclusions apply to all sections of this policy. They exist either because the loss is better addressed through maintenance, or because insuring the exposure would be commercially unworkable, or because the law restricts what may be insured.

- Wear and tear, gradual deterioration, rot, corrosion, settlement, shrinkage or manufacturing defects.
- Deliberate or criminal acts by you, by anyone living with you, or by anyone acting on your behalf.
- War, invasion, terrorism, civil commotion, and contamination by radioactivity or nuclear fuel.
- Storm damage to fences, gates and hedges.
- Damage caused by pets, vermin, insects or wild animals, other than impact damage to the building.
- The cost of repairing the source of an escape of water, oil or central heating fluid.
- Confiscation or destruction by order of any government or public authority.
- Any consequence of a data breach, hacking or computer virus, other than physical damage to the equipment itself.
- Loss of, or damage to, property held in trust or on commission for which a specific policy is required.

Sums that fall below the excess are not payable, and where loss is caused jointly by an insured event and an excluded cause, we will pay only the portion attributable to the insured event, as agreed with the loss adjuster appointed to the claim.

16. Excesses

The excess is the first part of each claim that you pay yourself. The standard excess is £250, and higher excesses apply to specific causes of loss. The applicable excess is always shown on your policy schedule. Choosing a higher voluntary excess reduces the premium at renewal, but does not change the specific excesses listed below, which are fixed policy conditions.

Type of claim	Excess (sample figures)
Standard buildings and contents claim	£250
Flood (any section)	£500
Escape of water from fixed installations	£350
Subsidence, landslip or heave	£1,000 (per building, per period of insurance)
Theft or attempted theft	£250
Accidental damage extension claim	£250
Windscreen-type glass in outbuildings	£250

Only one excess applies to each claim, even where the claim spans two sections — for example, an escape of water damaging both the floor and belongings. Where two specific excesses could apply, the higher one is deducted once. Excesses apply separately to buildings claims and to contents claims that arise from entirely different events.

17. Conditions and Security Requirements

You must take reasonable care to keep the home and its contents in good condition and must comply with the security conditions shown on the schedule. Standard security requires five-lever mortice deadlocks or multi-point locking on final exit doors, and key-operated window locks on all accessible ground floor windows. Where your schedule specifies enhanced security, the stated requirements must be satisfied in full, and claims arising through failure to comply may be reduced or declined.

If the home is unoccupied for more than 30 consecutive days, cover for theft, malicious damage, escape of water and glass breakage is suspended until you return, unless we agree otherwise. For unoccupied periods between 31 and 60 days, we may maintain full cover on condition that water is drained down or the system is inspected weekly. Long-term unoccupancy requires a specific endorsement and attracts an additional premium.

You must inform us of any material change of circumstances, including change of use, structural alterations, convictions, and any bankruptcy or insolvency proceedings. Failure to disclose material information may make the policy void from inception. Property insurance operates on the principle of utmost good faith, which requires both parties to disclose all facts that would influence a prudent underwriter.

18. Claims Procedure

If you need to make a claim, follow the five steps below. Claims may be notified at any time through the Omen claims portal, by telephone, or by email; the contact details appear on your policy schedule. You should notify us within 48 hours of discovering the loss, and in any event as soon as reasonably possible.

- Step 1 — Make the situation safe and take reasonable steps to prevent further damage; do not dispose of damaged items before they have been inspected or photographed.
- Step 2 — Notify us within 48 hours, describing the event, the date, and the items or damage involved; for theft, also report the matter to the police and obtain an incident reference number.
- Step 3 — Provide evidence within 30 days: photographs, receipts, bank statements, valuations for high-value items, and any requested documentation listed in the claim acknowledgement.
- Step 4 — Allow our appointed loss adjuster or contractor to inspect the damage; emergency repairs may proceed immediately where they reduce the size of the loss, and reasonable costs are reimbursed.
- Step 5 — Settlement is issued once the claim is validated; replacement items are sourced and dispatched directly, and building works are carried out by our approved network contractors.

Where an item is being replaced under new-for-old cover, replacement is with the nearest equivalent model available at the time of settlement; where the exact item is discontinued, we pay the cost of the closest equivalent specification. Any claim payment is made to you, or jointly to you and any mortgage lender with an interest in the property, within 10 working days of settlement terms being agreed.

Fraudulent claims invalidate the policy from the date of the fraudulent act, and we may report the matter to the police and to the industry claims database. Examples of fraud include exaggerating the value of lost items, listing items that never existed, and staging a loss. Subsequent policies elsewhere may be declined following a fraud marker.

19. How Sums Insured Are Calculated

The buildings sum insured is calculated on the rebuilding cost, not the market value, of the property. Rebuilding cost is estimated using the floor area multiplied by the current rebuilding cost per square foot for the construction type and region, plus the cost of demolitions, site clearance, professional fees at 15 per cent of the reinstatement cost, and compliance with current building regulations. Flats in blocks are often insured on a communal basis through the freeholder; contents cover remains your responsibility.

The contents sum insured is the replacement cost as new of everything that would fall out of the house if you turned it upside down. Many households under-insure their clothing, linen and children's toys; a room-by-room inventory is the most reliable method. Sums insured are index-linked at each renewal, meaning they rise automatically in line with the general index of prices applicable to home insurance, so cover does not erode with inflation.

The average provision applies where a sum insured is insufficient: if the contents sum insured is £40,000 but the true replacement cost is £50,000, the home is insured for 80 per cent of its value, and a £10,000 claim would be settled at £8,000 less the excess. Reviewing sums insured annually is the policyholder's responsibility.

20. Optional Extras

The Omen Shield policy can be extended with the following optional extras. Each extra is shown separately on the schedule with its own limit and premium, and each can be added or removed at renewal or, subject to administration charges, at any mid-term adjustment.

- Home Emergency — a 24/7 emergency helpline with call-out and temporary repair costs up to £500 per incident for burst pipes, boiler failure, lock-out, roof damage and pest infestation.
- Legal Expenses — up to £50,000 of legal costs for disputes arising from the home, employment of domestic staff, personal injury and consumer disputes.
- Specified Bicycle Cover — an individual sum insured for each bicycle, valid away from the home subject to an approved lock.
- Excess Waiver — removes the standard £250 excess in exchange for a small premium loading; specific excesses for flood, subsidence and escape of water still apply.
- Home Electrical Extension — covers power surge damage from the public supply and accidental failure of domestic appliances up to £4,000.

Adding the accidental damage extension is the most popular choice for family households; garden equipment cover limits can be increased to £5,000 where expensive machinery or furniture is present, and the personal possessions section can be extended to worldwide all-risks with no individual territory limit.

21. Cooling-Off Period

You may cancel this policy within 14 days of receiving the full policy documentation and receive a full refund of the premium paid, provided no claim has been made and none is pending. This statutory cooling-off period is designed to allow the policy documents to be read and compared with alternatives. Cancellation during the cooling-off period must be notified by letter, email or telephone, and refunds are issued to the original payment method within 10 working days.

If a claim has been made during the cooling-off period, the full premium remains payable for the period of insurance. The cooling-off period applies to new policies, renewals where the contract is re-underwritten, and mid-term adjustments that materially widen cover; it does not apply to pure renewals on unchanged terms.

22. Renewal and Cancellation

This policy runs for 12 months. Renewal invitations are issued 21 days before expiry, together with a statement of any changes to premium, cover and terms. If you choose not to renew, take no action and cover will lapse automatically at expiry; there is no obligation to notify us, though we may contact you to confirm. If we choose not to renew, we will give you 21 days' written notice, and any return premium is calculated pro rata.

Mid-term cancellation by you returns premium on a pro rata basis less an administration charge of £35, where no claim has occurred in the current period. Mid-term cancellation by us, following fraud or a material breach of conditions, returns no premium. Where the policy is financed through a credit agreement, cancellation terms of the credit agreement take precedence over the return-premium rules stated here.

23. Complaints Procedure

If you have a complaint about this policy, about a claim, or about any service you have received, contact the Omen customer relations team first. Complaints are acknowledged within 5 working days and resolved within 8 weeks, or you will receive an explanation of the delay and an indication of when a decision can be expected. Full details of the complaints procedure, including the fictional Omen Financial Ombudsman referral rights, are set out in the customer charter document.

Complaints about claims handling may be escalated to the independent loss adjuster supervising the claim at any time. Nothing in this procedure affects your legal rights, and the fictional regulatory environment described in these sample documents mirrors a typical consumer-protection regime.

24. Glossary of Defined Terms

Term	Meaning in this wording (fictional)
Sum insured	The maximum amount we will pay for each section in any one period of insurance.
Excess	The first amount of each claim that you pay yourself, as set out in Section 16.
New-for-old	Replacement of damaged items with new equivalents without deduction for wear and tear.
Reinstatement	Rebuilding or repairing the property to a condition substantially the same as new.
Average	The provision reducing claim payments in proportion to under-insurance.
Insured event	A cause of loss listed in this wording, such as fire, flood or theft.
Period of insurance	The 12 months for which cover is provided, as shown on the schedule.
Index-linking	Automatic annual adjustment of sums insured in line with the relevant price index.

25. Endorsement Schedule and Notes

Endorsements amend the standard wording to reflect your individual circumstances. Any endorsements applying to your policy are listed on the schedule with a reference number. Sample endorsements include HOM-END-01, removing the 30-day unoccupancy restriction for addresses with house-sitting arrangements; HOM-END-02, increasing the single article limit to £5,000 for specified jewellery; and HOM-END-03, extending personal possessions to worldwide cover with no item limit for photographic equipment.

This sample wording ends with the standard fictional signature block. Omen United Insurance is authorised and regulated by the fictional Omen Financial Conduct Register, firm reference number 000000-SAMPLE. This document is a demonstration artefact: no real cover is provided, no real firm exists, and all figures are illustrative.